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Sugar and Behaviour: What the Research Says

Plus a sensible festive sweets plan · Ages 2–4

The belief that sugar causes hyperactivity is very common, but controlled studies don't support it. Sugar still matters for teeth and overall health, so moderation is wise.

What the research found

- ○ A meta-analysis of controlled studies found that sugar does not affect the behaviour or thinking of children (Wolraich, Wilson & White, 1995).
- ○ Mothers who believed their sons had been given sugar rated them as more hyperactive, even though the drink was sugar-free (Hoover & Milich, 1994).

What really winds kids up

- ○ Excitement and new places
- ○ Crowds and noise
- ○ Late nights and missed naps
- ○ Hunger (sweets instead of meals)

A sensible sweets plan

- ○ Sweets after a meal, not instead of one
- ○ Small pieces, served on a plate
- ○ Water instead of sweet drinks
- ○ Brush teeth before bed

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Wolraich, M. L., Wilson, D. B., & White, J. W. (1995). The effect of sugar on behavior or cognition in children: A meta-analysis. JAMA, 274(20), 1617–1621.

Hoover, D. W., & Milich, R. (1994). Effects of sugar ingestion expectancies on mother-child interactions. Journal of Abnormal Child Psychology, 22(4), 501–515.

General information, not medical advice.